

Tavi's Small-Step Trail

A gentle story about finding your own way
forward



Ages 3-5 read-aloud

Tavi's Small-Step Trail

Pause. Peek. Pick one step.

Read aloud slowly. Pause wherever your child wants to join, notice, or wonder.

1 Tavi the young tortoise had an important job: carry the curly leaf banner to the pond parade. He polished his shell. He practiced his wave. Slowly, proudly, off he went.



2 Drip on a fern. Drop on a rock.
Drip-drop on Tavi's nose! Three
ducklings marched behind him: left,
right, waddle-waddle-right.



3 Around the bend spread a puddle -
wide as seven tortoise steps. The old
dry trail was under all that wiggly
water.



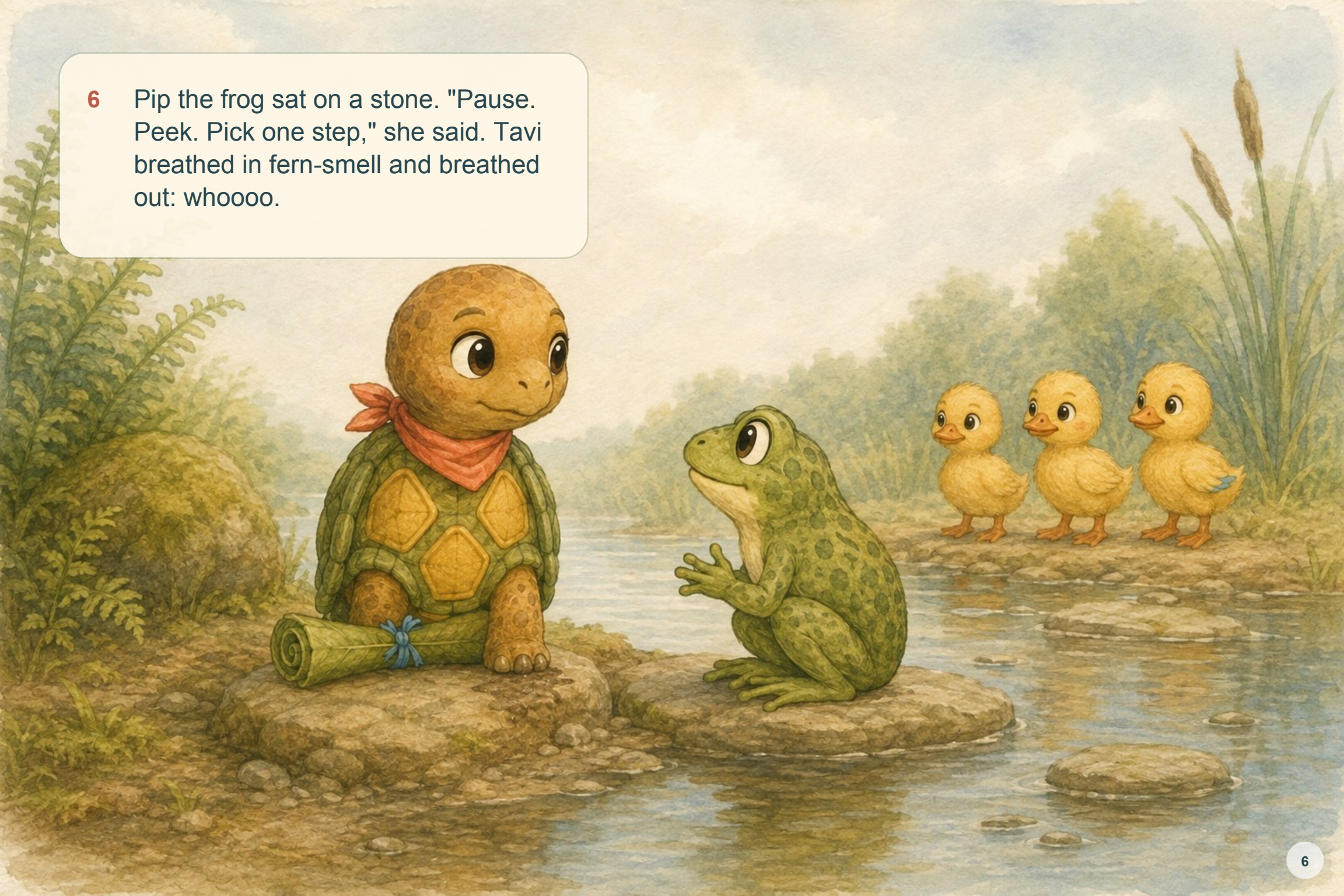
4 Tavi stretched one long, long leg toward the middle. Sploop! Mud kissed his toes. He pulled back fast. "I can't do this!"



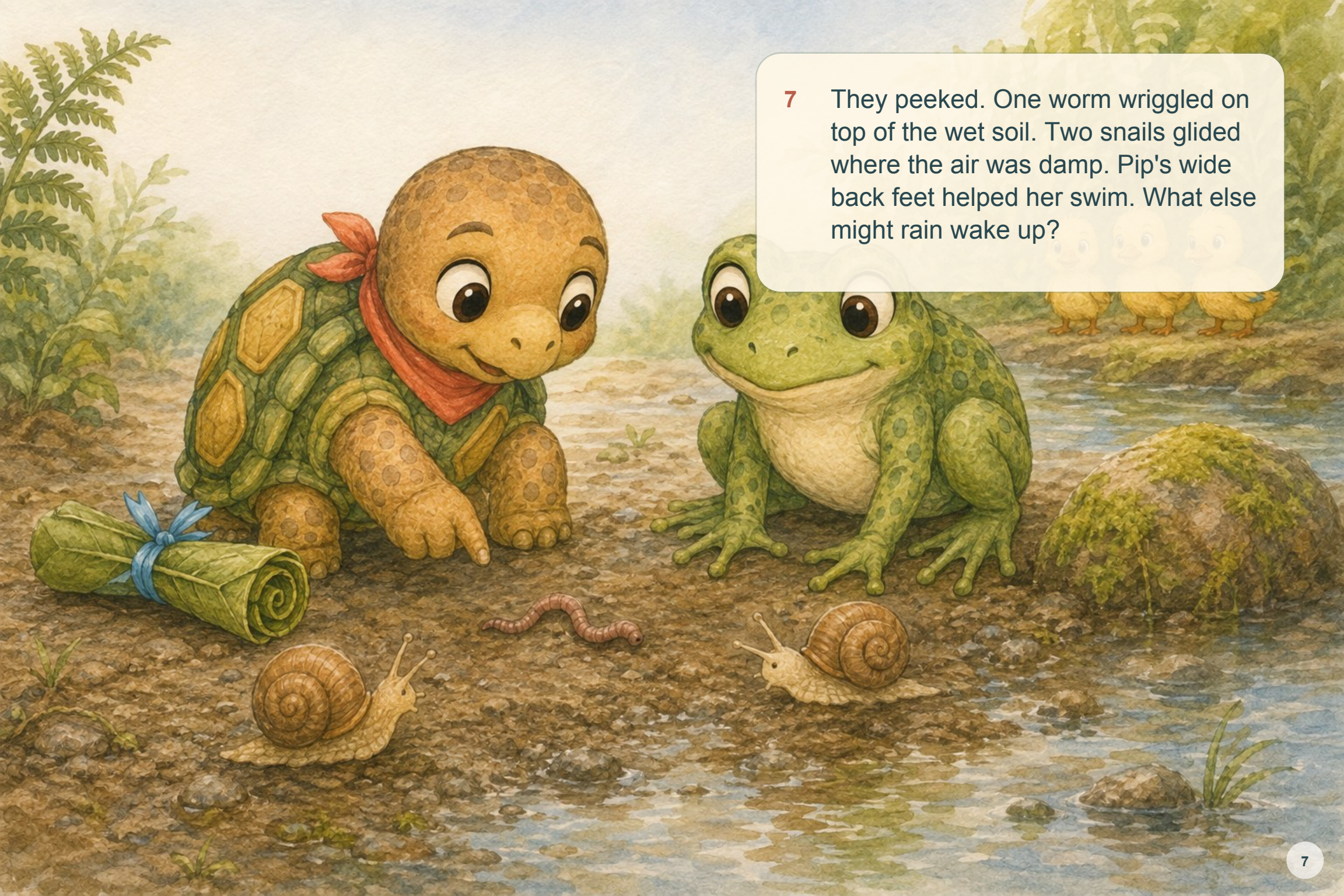
5 His neck felt tight. His eyes felt stinging. "I'm frustrated," Tavi said. The ducklings stopped. They did not rush him.



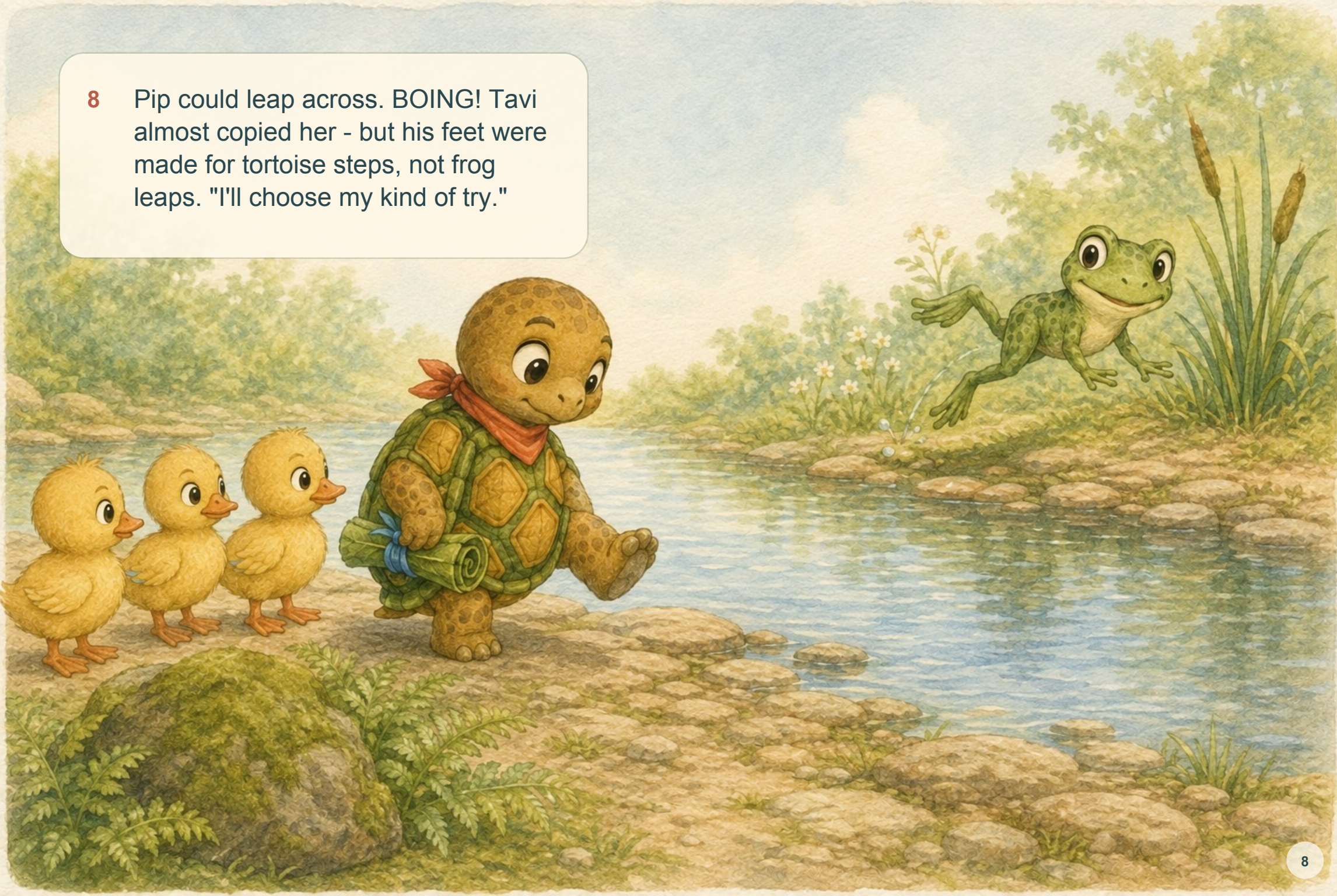
6 Pip the frog sat on a stone. "Pause. Peek. Pick one step," she said. Tavi breathed in fern-smell and breathed out: whoooo.



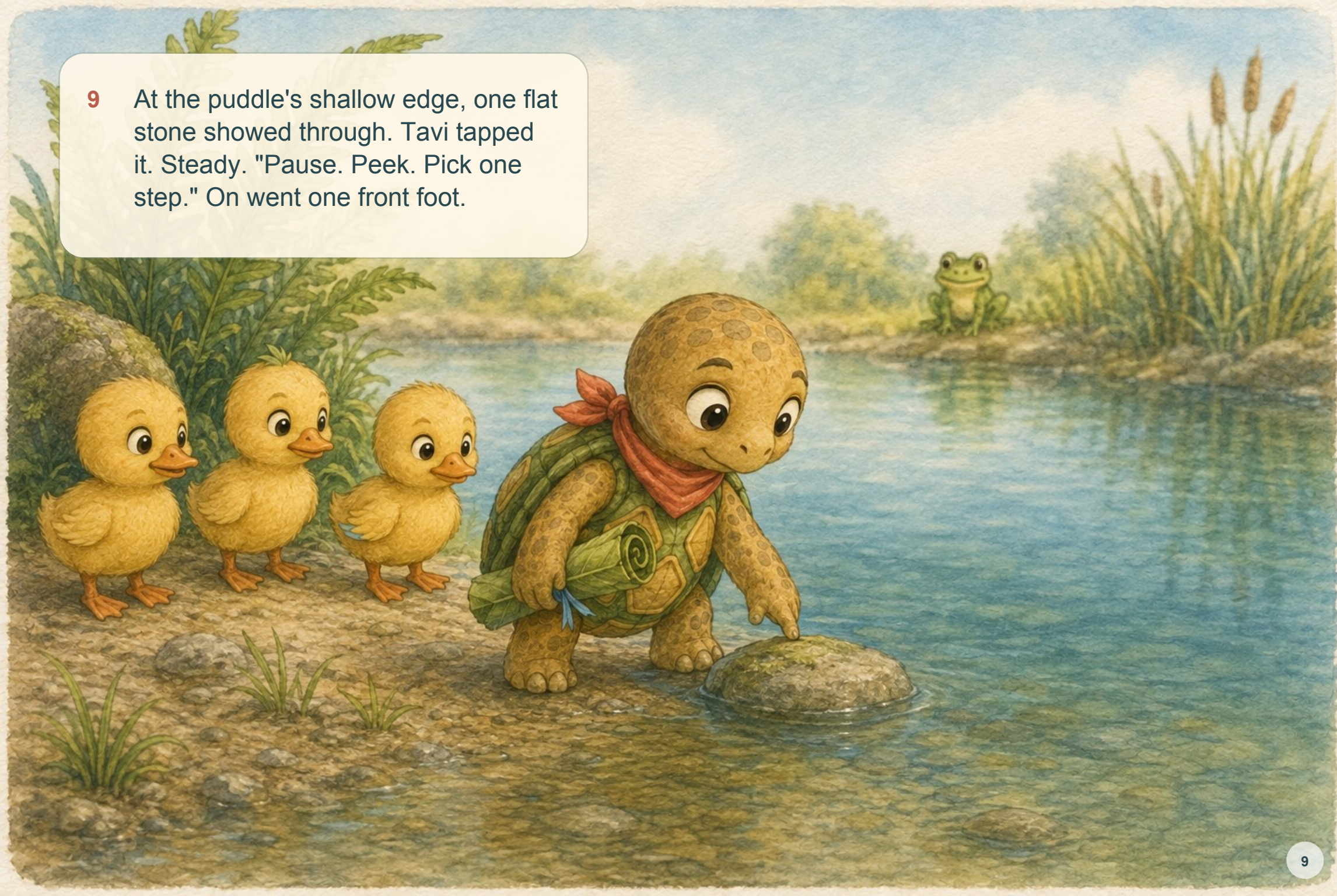
7 They peeked. One worm wriggled on top of the wet soil. Two snails glided where the air was damp. Pip's wide back feet helped her swim. What else might rain wake up?



- 8 Pip could leap across. BOING! Tavi almost copied her - but his feet were made for tortoise steps, not frog leaps. "I'll choose my kind of try."



9 At the puddle's shallow edge, one flat stone showed through. Tavi tapped it. Steady. "Pause. Peek. Pick one step." On went one front foot.



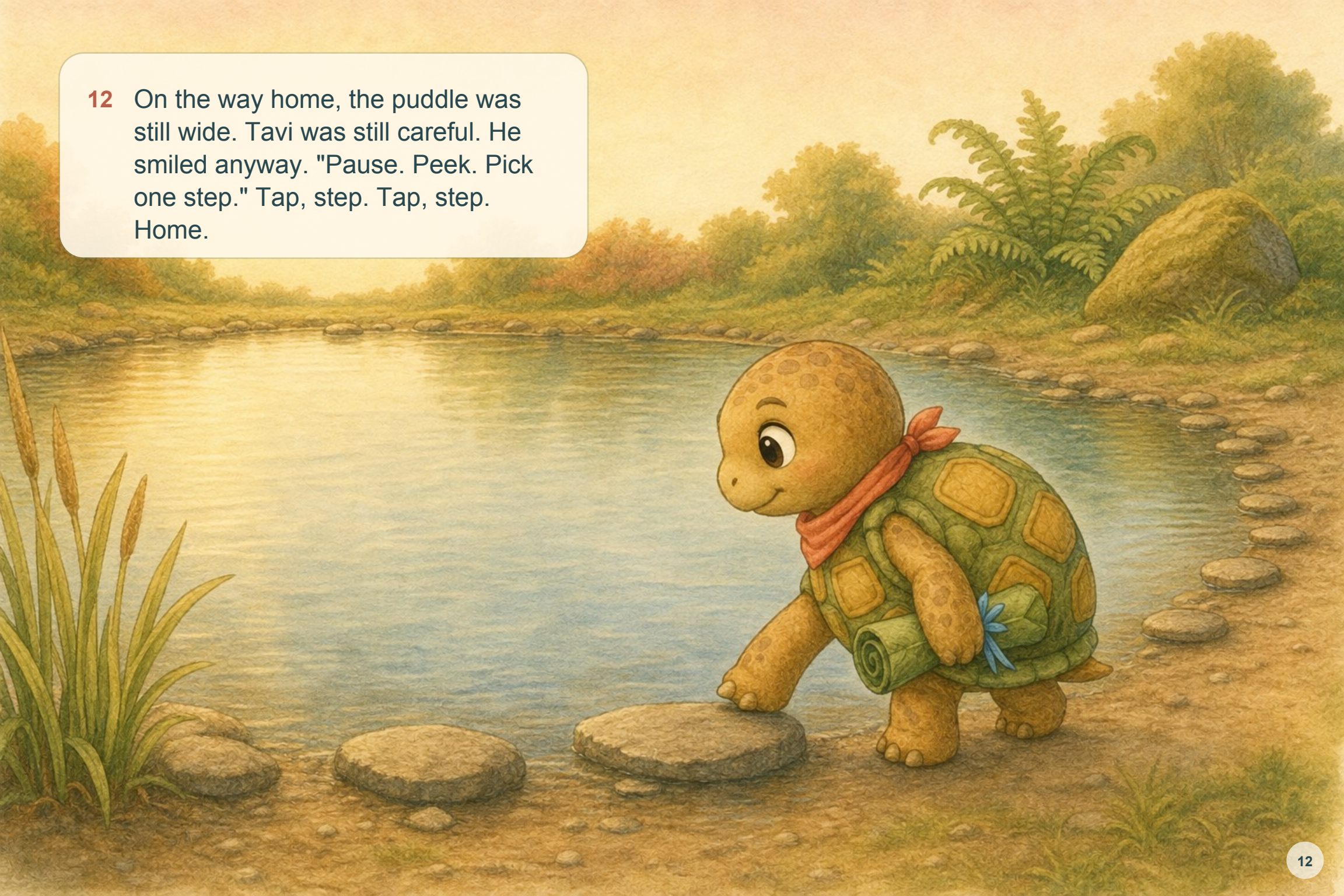
10 Tap, step. Tap, step. Tavi followed the shallow edge - not fast, not splashy, but forward. The ducklings followed his careful path. Waddle-waddle-WHEE!



11 At the pond, Tavi uncurled the banner. PARADE TODAY! Pip cheered. The ducklings bowed. Tavi's muddy toes tingled with pride.



12 On the way home, the puddle was still wide. Tavi was still careful. He smiled anyway. "Pause. Peek. Pick one step." Tap, step. Tap, step. Home.



Try Tavi's three small steps



PAUSE

Take one slow breath.



PEEK

What can you notice?



PICK

Choose one small step.

Careful can still move forward.

**A wide puddle stops Tavi's important parade
job.**

With a pause, a careful peek, and one tortoise-sized step, Tavi
discovers that brave does not have to mean fast or splashy.

Pause. Peek. Pick one step.